Case Study 11

Virtual Experiments

As you have learned in Section Three of Module Three, researchers cannot conduct "just any" experiment on humans. Because of ethical concerns, many psychological experiments stopped in the 1970s. In contemporary society, some of the previously prohibited experiments can now be conducted in the safer environment of *cyberspace*. Researchers at University College of London, in an effort to duplicate Milgram's obedience studies from the 1960s, had participants administer shocks to a human-looking avatar (electronic image) in virtual reality instead of using a live subject.

The researchers found that participants in the virtual environment acted as though the situation were real. Participants administered a series of word association memory tests to the virtual human (a female) and when she gave an incorrect answer, participants were invited to give her an electric shock. For each subsequent incorrect answer, participants were asked to increase the voltage.

Of the 34 participants in the study, 23 saw and heard the virtual woman while 11 communicated with her only through text. The results showed that individuals who could see and hear the virtual woman responded quite differently from those communicating only through text. All the participants communicating through text administered the maximum number of shocks to the virtual woman but only 74% of the participants who saw and heard the virtual woman administered the maximum number of shocks.

According to the lead researcher in this study, "the results demonstrate that even though all experimental participants knew the situation was unreal, they nevertheless tended to respond as if it were." With this in mind, perhaps virtual reality experimentation can be used to perform research that might otherwise be unethical.